

Some say the real India is to be found in its villages; others would like to think that India is best represented by its big cities and industrial centres. For me, India has always been an atmosphere, an emotional more than a geographical entity; but if I have to transpose this rather nebulous concept into something more concrete, then I would say that India is really to be found in its small towns.

Small-town India—that's *my* India. The India of Shamli and Shahganj, Panipat and Pipalkoti, Alwar and Ambala and Alleppey, Kalka and Kasauli and Kolar Goldfields, and thousands of others along the rivers, along the coasts, straddling the mountains or breaking up the monotony of scrub and desert. Taken together, they set the cities at naught. They are the heart of India, an untapped source of vast human potential, largely ignored except when elections come round.

I suppose I'm prejudiced, being a small-town boy myself. My bio-data simply reads: Born in Kasauli, small boy in Jamnagar, bigger boy in Dehra Dun, schoolboy in Simla, sundry adventures in Agra, Ambala and Rishikesh, and now holed up in Mussoorie! *Dihli dur ast....* Delhi is a far cry. And Bombay, where have *you* been all my life? Have I missed something very precious? Have I, in choosing the dusty lanes of Roorkee or Shahjahanpur, missed out on the sights of Calcutta and Madras, or lost my last chance to lean against the leaning tower of Pisa or savour the aromas of the Venetian canals? If I have, so be it. Our own aromas are sufficiently interesting. I will continue to write of the residents of Gali Ram Rai and other *mohallas*, and leave it to more restless souls to sing the praises of five-star cuisine and the fascinating world of airports after dark.

Small towns don't change in the way that cities change. It is still possible to find the old landmarks and sometimes the old people. There is a timelessness about small-town and cantonment India that I have tried to capture in a story like 'Time Stops at Shamli'. It begins like 'The Night Train at Deoli' in my earlier collection, but this time I step off the train, explore the place, discover a boarding-house inhabited by a number of lonely